the area.[17] These newly mapped architectural remains essentially outline a network of large and small structures marking passages along the Hari Rud, seemingly punctuated by nodes of culmination, quite possibly like the originally sizeable complex at Chisht (discussed further below). While similar exploration, mapping, and documentation are still to be conducted for Shah-i Mashhad and its vicinity of the lower Murghab River (Figures 4.2 and 4.3), re-conceptualizing both of these magnificent monuments as integral nodes in networks facilitating travel and communication appears to be historically more accurate; moreover, such a contextualization helps to explain the complexes' lavishness and – above all – their prominent epigraphic programs.

Shah-i Mashhad (Gharjistan)

In his seminal work of 2009, F. B. Flood agreed with and adduced further evidence toward the scholarly consensus that Shansabani adherence to and patronage of the Karramiyya continued unfaltering through AH 595/1199 CE, "when the sultans of Ghur abruptly terminated their association with [them], embracing the orthodox *madhhab*s … of Islam instead."[18] He cited four additional points in support, including the possibility that the tomb–*madrasa* complex of Shah-i Mashhad – dated to AH 561–570/1165–1175 CE, as noted above – was a Karrami institution (Figure 4.1). Another point was the erection of the *minar* of Jam-Firuzkuh in *c.* AH 569/1174 CE (Figure 4.18), whose epigraphic program of all of Qur'an XIX (Surat Maryam) has been convincingly interpreted as a Karrami proclamation (cf. Appendix, Afghanistan VII: 5).[19] Flood's third evidentiary *datum* was a luxurious, four-volume illuminated Qur'an, dated by colophon to AH 584–585/1189 CE: the extensive commentary (*tafsir*) copied at the end of each Sura was originally composed by the leading Karrami of eleventh-century Nishapur, Abu Bakr 'Atiq ibn Muhammad al-Surabadi (d. *c.* AH 494/1101 CE). According to Flood, the commentary indicated that this Qur'an "was among the manuscripts commissioned by the Ghurids for a Karrami madrasa," perhaps even Shah-i Mashhad. Finally, Juzjani described Ghiyath al-Din's "conversion" to the Shafi'i *madhhab* as being effected through a dream or vision that came upon the sultan sometime in AH 595/1199 CE.[20]

However, there is equally compelling evidence, both material as well as circumstantial, that the Firuzkuh Shansabanis patronized sects beyond the Karramiyya long before AH 595/1199 CE, much earlier than Flood and others have proposed. The Ghaznavids and Saljuqs – the Shansabanis' predecessors and contemporaries (respectively) in the region – had benefited from fomenting competition among the various schools of legal–theological thought while attempting to establish and maintain control over various parts of Khurasan. The juridico-intellectual rivalry was the by-product of